lamentable failure of Lord Irwin to effectively push through his policy of ‘efficient despotism’ and grant the Lahore conspirators an amnesty was in no small part linked to the abject failure of the leading Congress politicians to come to the assistance of their fellow countrymen and put pressure on Lord Irwin to do exactly that when it was most needed.

‘Efficient despotism’ worked in other respects. One learns, for example, of an event in 1933, when there was a forty-five-day hunger strike in the cellular jail in the Andaman Islands, when caution was urged in a manner that it was not in 1929–30 when the Lahore conspirators were on trial. On that occasion, the hunger strike ran from 12 May to 26 June. It involved no less than fifty-eight inmates. It was moreover accompanied by another twenty who refused to work as well. In the end, three hunger strikers died in the cellular jail. From the Indian Medical Service, there was a Lieutenant-Colonel F.A. Barker who had served in the Lahore Central Jail during the Lahore Conspiracy Case in 1929 when the hunger strike was being used by the detainees as a tool of resistance. When he was sent to the Andaman Islands half-way through the hunger strike of the prisoners there, he was able to report that there was a humane way of force-feeding the prisoners without occasioning unnecessary death by inflicting additional injury upon them. He advised that when artificial feeding was undertaken, the rubber tubes should be moistened with olive oil and only then inserted into the nasal passage as this would not interfere with their breathing.[4] This technique of humane force-feeding was largely absent in the case of the Lahore conspirators, who suffered grievously at the hands of prison wardens, who often delighted in inflicting untold pain on the hunger strikers when they resisted the forced feeding. Should there be an apology for that?

Before this question is answered, it is as well to remember that the issue of an apology is complex and controversial. Apologies have become all too commonplace these days. Jawad Iqbal has referred to Spanish atrocities in South America in a past age and the demand that Spain now apologize for such misdeeds. He pointed out that for President Andres Manuel Lopez Obrador of Mexico to be ‘asking the Spanish to say sorry for their historical misdeeds is just a political gimmick, making a mockery of the actual